

BH

Pilpul

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Champaign Illinois

Lag Bomer 5776

Parshas Bhar

in europe of the late 1500s there were many yeshivas, centers of torah learning which produced many great sages. during this period of time many novel ways of learning torah were discovered. the most famous and difficult one was the pilpul, a intellectual exircise in which the student must connect diffrent concepts one to another by uncovering the basic principale of logic in which both of the concepts are based upon. it has become the custom to test a bar mitzvah boys intellectual compacity by asking him to prepare a pilpul. so without further ado here i go...

An older Jewish woman from Brooklyn goes in search of a famous guru. She takes a plane to India, and then hikes into the mountains with local guides. All in all, it takes her months of hardship to track down this guru. When she finds him he is on the peak of the tallest mountain, in the middle of some kind of ritual which lasts for days and the guru's many followers won't let her see him. Eventually she reaches the hallowed portals. There she is told firmly that due to the long lines she can only say EIGHT words to the guru. "Fine", she says. She is ushered into the inner sanctum where the wise guru is seated, ready to bestow spiritual blessings upon his eager initiates. Just before

she reaches his throne she is once again reminded: "Remember, just EIGHT words." Finally, the guru is ready to receive visitors and calls for the woman to be admitted. She stands before the famous guru. "Bernie" she says, "it's your mother, time to come home!"

Speaking about mountain's, this week's torah portion is parshat behar- the Hebrew word for mountain.

But before we delve into parshat behar, Let's pause a minute and turn a couple of chapters back in the story of the torah, to before our forefather Jacob went down to Egypt, he had just settled into the land near the ancient day metropolis named shchem, when tragedy strikes, his daughter dinah had gone out to survey the land and was captured and forcibly taken by the ruler of shchem's very own son! Hearing of the outrage two of Jacobs sons, shimon and levi, courageously wage war against schem and his men and fight their way until they redeem Dinah.

The verse states "vayikach ish charbi"- and each man took his sword, genesis 34;25. According to tradition shimon and levi were 13 at the time of this incident, and yet the torah describes them as men- 'each man took his sword' from here originates the idea of a bar mitzvah boy, that at age 13 a child ceases to be a child and becomes a man. For this is the age when one matures intellectually, when one fully grasps the concepts of good and evil and the consequence of following either path in his life.

The story of the torah is not just a beautiful pastime, rather it gives us insight into our day to day life, and in this case an insight into the relationship of a bar mitzvah boy and god.

on the one hand the emphasis of a bar mitzvah is intellect, one must strive to understand god and his ways, by learning the torah which is god's wisdom, and by delving into the logical and Kabbalistic explanations behind the commandments. On the other hand, the story of shimon and levi is one of self-sacrifice, two boys standing up against a mighty tyrant to defend their sister, an act which defies logic. Yet being that it was what the situation demanded of them, they went ahead full heartedly, teaching us that a bar mitzvah boys relationship with god must be one based on self-sacrifice, one which transcends logic. But how can one accomplish this, how can we straddle two seemingly contradictory concepts into one divine service, into one small bar mitzvah boy!?

Two days ago was the holiday of lag baomer, the celebration of the yahrzeit of the great sage rabbi shimon bar Yochai, who lived during the period of the roman rule of oppression over the holy land.

Rabbi shimon had many great teachings, the one I would like to discuss is in ethics of our fathers, in which it is our custom to learn a chapter of every week after the mincha services of Shabbat. In this week's chapter (in the 13th Mishna) rabbi shimon taught; "there are 3 crowns, the crown of torah, the crown of priesthood and the crown of kingship but the crown of a good name is the most important of them all" one receives a good name by doing good deeds, mitzvot. So in essence

rabbi shimon is stressing to us the importance of mitzvot over torah, of action over study. But this is puzzling for rabbi shimons whole life was dedicated to torah studying, for 13 years while he hid in a cave in refuge of the romans all he did was study, in Talmudic terms- toraso umanuso , learning torah was his occupation. So why is rabbi shimon of all people the one stressing the importance of action versus study!?

Like a good Jew I will answer these question with a question, the timeless search for man's purpose in life. The masters of the kabbalah expound upon this question; our world is a flawed one, where man's everyday commitment to honesty is challenged, living in a society where values like truth and integrity are shunned upon. And unfortunately many a man has succumbed to these pressures, for man himself is flawed. So why did god create this world, why was he not content with the many angels who sing his praises all day?

Rather, it is to test the power of godliness, to see if good can withstand the test of evil, if in a world devoid of spirituality, a chosen nation will arise to light a small candle, to usher in some godliness, proving that a small light can indeed dispel a lot of darkness. This is man's mission in life, and to a Jew in particular, that thru following god's directives, his torah and mitzvot, we create a dwelling place for god himself in this world "lasos lo yisbareich dirah batachtonim".

But this mission is not easy, for the worlds arguments are persuasive and its offer of materialism an enticing one. some claim that the only way to withstand the test, is to run away from it, like our friend the spiritual guru, they would rather live

in a place in which society cannot affect them, thereby assuring their own spiritual sanctity. But Judaism rejects this notion, for our purpose is to bring god into the darkness, to prove to a world which deems the ways of torah and mitzvot old and outdated, that to the contrary, especially in these modern times are when they are most relevant. But the question persists, if we are to properly delve into society, if we are to fully invest ourselves into the mundane, then how are we to remain spiritually intact, to live on high yet remain below?

In order to understand this concept, I would like to share a Chassidic Story. In the mid-1800s lived a Chassidic master named rabbi Meir, who hailed from the Russian village of premishlan, it is related that the mikveh (ritual bath) in Rabbi Meir's neighborhood stood at the foot of a steep mountain. When the slippery weather came, everyone had to walk all the way around for fear of slipping on the mountain path and breaking their bones—everyone, that is, apart from Rabbi Meir, who walked down that path whatever the weather, and never slipped.

One icy day, Rabbi Meir set out as usual to take the direct route to the mikveh. Two guests were visiting the area. These two young men did not believe in supernatural achievements, and when they saw Rabbi Meir striding downhill with sure steps as if he were on a solidly paved highway, they wanted to demonstrate that they too could negotiate the hazardous path. As soon as Rabbi Meir entered the mikveh building, they took to the road. After only a few steps they stumbled and slipped, and needed medical treatment for their injuries.

when these two men were fully healed they mustered the courage to approach the tsaddik with their question: why was it that no man could cope with that treacherous path, yet the Rebbe never stumbled? Replied Rabbi Meir: “az men iz farbunden oif aiben falt men nisht arup unten”-If a man is bound up on high, he doesn’t fall down below

In this beautiful story lies the answer, one must remain connected on high in order to assure he does not fall below, and how does one remain connected on high? for this we have our rabbis and teachers, men who dedicate their lives to the study of the torah, and the spreading of its teachings. men who live on a higher spiritual plane, men who- as the fifth Chabad rebbe was fond of saying- live a handbreadth higher. They ensure that our spiritual needs do not go unattended, by teaching the torah to us ordinary folk, albeit for just a few moments every day, and although this time frame might be small, its affects loom large. For it is these few precious moments which gives us the ability to keep our head above the water, enabling us to remain focused on our goal; to bring godliness into a world which at first glance devoid of its presence.

This is why rabbi Shimon was the one to stress the importance of action, being a great rabbi he wanted to explain to all the future rabbis of the upcoming generations, what the role of a rabbi is, that leaning and studying god’s wisdom is not an end for itself, rather it is a tool in the divine plan of creation, enabling man to properly perform good deeds. And this knowledge must permeate one’s study’s, knowing that that his

learning and teaching, are the very key which enables gods master plan to be completed.

So we see that man can live a paradox, an ordinary Jew can be fully vested in the mundane, yet simultaneously connected to the divine, a rabbi can be fully vested in to the divine, yet simultaneously connected to the mundane, for the key is to remove our own self ambitions, to remove our own egos, and to give our utmost dedication to god's plan. For when we are removed from the picture it enables us to transcend our finite abilities, and then we begin to see the world thru god's lenses, a world in which the mundane and the divine cease to be contradictory and coexist as one.

This is what every bar mitzvah boy must know, that although we might demand of him in his divine service to perform to seemingly polar opposites, if he embraces this role with self-removal and the utmost dedication, then it is possible. Of course we are not demanding for him to do two opposites at once, rather than in every situation that arises he should try to see it thru god's eyes, using logic when possible and thus that transcends logic when it is not.

Let us return to parshat behar, our portions primary focus is on the agricultural laws pertaining to the land of Israel, the everyday tasks of an ordinary Jew, but shouldn't we discuss lofty spiritual concepts in a portion entitled, "mountain"- referring to the giving of the torah on MT Sinai, the greatest godly revelation in the history of mankind? Or, perhaps the most spiritual and lofty concepts are those that affect the most mundane, perhaps the portion is telling us that that the simple

laws of agriculture hold within it the spiritual sanctity of mount Sinai, allowing all of society to live a handbreadth higher.

So as I begin to prepare for the next step of my journey, I look back at my childhood here in Champaign, and although growing up as the only religious kid my age might have been tough i have come to the recognition that it's been a blessing in disguise, for it has given me the opportunity to become a role model for the other children, to show them how relevant torah and mitzvot truly are, like how playing sports while wearing a yarmulke, poses no contradiction at all. bringing the rebbes vision to reality here in Champaign Illinois. I will try to use this experience to enhance the next stage of my life, balancing the learning of a yeshiva bocher with the challenges of adolescence together as one.

I would like to thank my parents for all of the thought and effort they put into every aspect of my upbringing, for always being there and being so supportive in so many ways.

I'd like to give a very big thank you to my great grandparents, grandparents and so much extended family who have made great effort to be here today and celebrate.

Thank you to the friends, cousins and classmates who traveled took the time and effort to travel from out of town. We spend a lot of time playing and studying over the phone and computer and it is amazing to have you in person here today And I'd like to thank each and every one of YOU!

Good Shabbos.

(based on likutei sichos parshas vayeshev chalek tes vov,
parshas behar-lagbeomer, chalek yud zayin)